

Viral Marketing: Garnier Fructis And Coca-Cola

When Garnier launched its Fructis shampoo, it was specifically targeted at the young upwardly-mobile consumer who had a penchant for a great brand, bundled with some obvious benefits. In the case of Fructis, the benefit was “five times stronger hair.”

The challenge was to present this benefit to consumers online and make them market the idea further. The result was the “World’s Longest and Strongest Braid” competition, created by C2W. The idea was simple but extremely powerful. Consumers could register on the site using their e-mail and create a Knot on the Fructis Braid, as their entry into the contest. They were instantly allotted a position number and the knot creation was actually visually presented in front of them. As a next step, the consumers were expected to “invite” their friends to visit the braid and add to their “visitor score.” The prize was based on the largest tribe members that a consumer could build. A record 76,000 consumers created their own knot on the braid and forwarded the link to more than 82,000 of their friends!

Coca-Cola India took the viral marketing idea to the wireless platform, driven by its regular TV advertising. During the launch of Vanilla Coke, consumers were prompted to send “WAKAW” to 8858. Immediately after that, consumers received a special message with a code, which they could forward to their friends. Once the friend received the message and actually sent the code to 8558, the original sender automatically entered into the lucky pool. However, the clever insight was that even *the recipient wanted to win*, and they started the chain messaging all over again. The promotion generated a whopping 2.26+ lakh SMSes!

June 2000, C2W’s revenues stood at Rs 83 lakh, with profits of Rs 7 lakh. In the last financial year, C2W did business of \$1.5 million, establishing itself as one of the more profitable online ventures.

How It Works

The concept of C2W is based on a simple idea—creating a window of interaction between consumers and the brand owner and then monetising their services. Take the example of Coke’s *Thanda Zone*. Unlike conventional TV advertisements, the *Thanda Zone* contest actually offers consumers an opportunity to interact and play with Hindi-movie personality and Coca-Cola ambassador Aamir Khan. The Zone comprises three contests built around the *Tapori*, *Punjabi* and *Bihari* ads of Coke, which made the slogan “*Thanda matlab Coca-Cola*” hot property today.

There Were Challenges, Too!

Kejriwal says that markets such as India and China are challenging. For instance, in India, Internet penetration is less than two per cent; India’s total interactive advertising market is less than 0.25 per cent of the total ad market; and the total ad market is less than two per cent of the GDP. In this space, C2W’s share of the Indian online ad market is 20 per cent.

In neighbouring China, which is a gigantic mobile market, Kejriwal says that barriers to entry are high; local partnerships are tough; and that creating media pull is expensive. Despite all this, C2W pioneered interactive mobile marketing in China. They attracted investment from Softbank Japan and Siemens AG, and have delivered 60 solutions including



The idea is to help consumers and participants get out of the stupid slogan contests and actually participate in interactive campaigns

Alok Kejriwal
CEO, C2W

the world’s largest wireless brand campaign for Coca-Cola. C2W has also delivered many first-of-its-kind mobile solutions.

The road ahead for C2W involves taking the C2W model into mature markets that offer scale. C2W will create interactive plug-and-play applications for brands that are hosted on different media. Simply put, these “advergAMES” can be offered to the same brands in developed markets to be “positioned” on their Web sites and/or portals. C2W also partners with portals to offer their products as a new offering for brands.

C2W is ambitious—its next few destinations are Thailand, Philippines and the UAE. C2W is in the process of launching a Web site in Thailand, where it plans to go with a franchisee-based business model. C2W will get a royalty for the brand, and will also have a share of the revenue.

Agencyfaqs.com asked Kejriwal this: despite being in an unconventional business in a new medium, what is that one factor that has made C2W a profitable venture today? It’s cost control, says Kejriwal, who uses a Delhi cell phone number whenever he is there, instead of using a roaming Mumbai number. No wonder the company, which started off as a one-man show, has 70 members on board today and a zero employee turnover rate.

Viral Marketing

The last time you received an SMS joke or a personal e-mail was probably just a couple of hours ago. Did you ask someone to send you that SMS or mail? Was it a planned communication? Definitely not, says Kejriwal. It is what the world does so naturally today—sending messages the viral way.

On a daily basis, millions of e-mails and SMSes are whizzing across the world—all forwards by friends, enemies, relatives and lovers crammed with jokes, advice, prayers, images and photos. Consumers have become “information relayers,” which reminds Kejriwal of the tribes in the *Phantom* series of comic books, who would pass messages across the jungle using their tom-toms. And brand owners are taking note of this with considerable delight.

It is a brand owner’s dream to introduce a message to a set of consumers and then have them work at popularising that message further by telling their friends and relatives. And that’s exactly what they are achieving using viral brand campaigns on the Internet and on the mobile.

Pulling You In—The Sweet Way

At the end of the day, it’s about what works. Intrusive or interruptive marketing is on its way out, as Kejriwal rightly points out. And when you have something like the contests on C2W, the customer—that is, you—is willingly pulled in. The brand promoter gets his ad across to you, and you view an ad so you get entered into a contest. You might even win. Everybody’s happy. ☐

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